

Back in the eighties when I was a little kid, my sister and I had a Saturday morning ritual.

We'd get up real early while Mum and Dad were still snoring.

We'd sneak into the kitchen, climb onto the bench, stretch up on our tippy-toes and grab the forbidden fruit . . . well, Froot Loops, which Mum only allowed us to eat on 'special occasions'.

(This was not one of them.)

Froot Loops contain no fruit. You'd get the same nutritional content if you heaped 40 tablespoons of sugar into a bowl and added a splash of milk. After two bowls of that sugary snack, I was Toucan Sam.

We'd eat our third bowl in front of the telly as we watched cartoons.

Cartoons were different back then. These days Disney has feel-good flicks like *Finding Nemo*—where a cute little clownfish with a big heart teaches us about the importance of marine biology, the urgency of environmental protection and why you should never let your differences hold you back.

In contrast, the old Looney Tunes cartoons we watched were chock-full of random and unexplained acts of violence—a perennially angry Elmer Fudd goes duck hunting, gets all wound up, loads his shotgun and shoots Daffy Duck in the face at point-blank range.

Hilarious.

Still, we sat through the cartoons to get to the *really* cool stuff:

The ads.

Back then toy ads were out of this world . . . unconstrained and unchecked by today's societal standards. The Mad Men of advertising fully understood pester power. Their ads got kids all hyped up, so they'd harass their parents for the new series of toys (and it was always a series).

For me it was G.I. Joe. For my sister it was Barbie. For my father it was a total pester-powered ambush as he rose from bed still groggy and unshaven.

Times have changed.